

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Name who contributed -> Name what they did -> Do not be vague

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

The next time you present work that involved others, name at least one contributor specifically before you present it.

BEST FOR

- Leading or managing teams
- Presenting work to senior stakeholders
- Building a culture of trust and recognition
- Any situation where others contributed to your output

PHRASE BANK

Shared Credit Phrases · Naming contributors

- "[Name] built the core of this — I want to make sure that is visible."
- "This came from [Name]'s analysis."
- "The credit for that insight goes to [Name]."
- "I could not have produced this without [Name] doing X."
- "[Name] spotted the problem we were about to miss."
- "That was [Name]'s recommendation — I ran with it."
- "Three people made this: [Name] did X, [Name] did Y, and [Name] did Z."
- "I want to be clear: this was a team effort. [Names] did the work."

Credit Framing · Making it feel natural

- "Before I present this — let me name who is actually behind it."
- "I want to start by attributing this properly."
- "The people who made this possible are..."
- "I am presenting but I did not build this alone."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague: 'A great team effort'
Better: I had a lot of help on this.
Best: [Name] built the analysis. [Name] caught the error. I pulled it together.
2. Weak: Taking full credit for collaborative work
Better: I worked with [Name] on this.
Best: Name each person's specific contribution before presenting the work.
3. Weak: Over-crediting: spreading it so thin no one seems particularly important
Better: A lot of people were involved.
Best: Name the two or three people whose contribution was most essential. Be specific.

DECISION TREE

If You are presenting work that involved others

Name contributors before or during the presentation.

"[Name] built the core of this — I want to make sure that is visible before we get into it."

If Someone else took the credit for your work

Name your contribution clearly and without aggression.

"I built the analysis behind that — I wanted to mention it for the record."

If You want to share credit but do not know the details

Find out before presenting. 'This was a team effort' without specifics is weak.

"Before I present — [Name] did the research, [Name] did the design."

If Credit-sharing sounds performative

Be specific. Vague credit sounds like it is for show.

"[Name] specifically spotted the data anomaly that changed everything."

SCENARIOS

Presenting to leadership on a team project

Name contributors in the opening. — "Before I walk you through this — [Name] built the financial model and [Name] led the research."

Receiving praise for a project that was collaborative

Redirect the credit to the team member who did the work. — "Thank you — though I want to make sure [Name] gets that credit. They drove this."

In a meeting where someone's contribution is being overlooked

Name it directly. — "I want to note that the idea we just discussed came from [Name]."

Writing a report on collaborative work

Name contributors explicitly in the document, not just in the acknowledgements. — "The analysis in section 3 was built by [Name]. The recommendations in section 5 draw on [Name]'s research."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When your individual contribution needs to be visible for legitimate reasons — e.g. a performance review where your specific work must be legible.
- When sharing credit for something that went wrong — ownership of failure is different from shared credit for success.
- When attributing credit to someone who did not contribute confuses accountability.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Attribution audit

Review the last thing you presented or sent. Were contributors named? Should they have been?

Day 2 — Name before presenting

The next time you present work, name the contributors before getting into the content.

Day 3 — Specific contribution

Give credit that names what specifically each person did, not just that they were involved.

Day 4 — In-the-moment credit

In a meeting, attribute an idea to the person who had it, in the moment.

Day 5 — Written credit

In one document or message, name contributors explicitly in the body rather than only in an acknowledgements section.

Day 6 — Redirect unearned credit

If you receive credit for something collaborative, redirect it to the person who earned it.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did contributors seem to feel more seen? Did your credibility increase or decrease? Did any credit-sharing feel hollow?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name contributors before or during the presentation — not after?
- Was the credit specific — naming what each person did?
- Did I avoid vague credit like 'team effort'?
- Did I avoid over-sharing credit so widely it lost meaning?

- Did I redirect unearned praise to the person who earned it?
- Was the credit genuine rather than performative?
- Did contributors seem to feel recognised?